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Ethnobotany of starter culture (Ranu) used in production of rice-beer (Handia) by Oraon tribes of Khunti district of Jharkhand

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Abstract : Ranu is the indigenous starter mixture used by the tribes of Jahrkhand for the preparation of rice based fermented alcoholic beverage handia. Handia is an essential drink of these communities and occupies a pivotal role socially, culturally and economically. It has religious uses and values and has an important place in every tribal festival. It is important to know the ethnobotany of ranu to decipher the medicinal properties of handia. Various plant parts are used for preparing ranu which are easily available in the forests of those areas. Therefore variation can be seen in the composition of ranu in different regions and different tribes. This paper deals with the composition of ranu as done by the Oraon tribes of Khunti district of Jharkhand.

Keywords : Rice-beer, Ranu tablets, Handia, Tribals, Starter culture, Medicinal plants

INTRODUCTION

Worldwide alcoholic beverages are of great significance but the tradition of using ethnic starter culture for fermentation of these beverages is common in Asian continent.[1] The starter culture preparation varies from region to region which involves the use of local food-crops, spices or herbs of a particular region.

In India, making use of starter culture for the preparation of fermented beverages has been widely documented in the North-East regions as well as in Orissa and West Bengal. *Apong* and *Ennog* (black rice beer) are the alcoholic beverages of Arunachal Pradesh and Assam respectively and use a culture called *ipoh*.[2] *Murcha* of Sikkim is used for making *Kodo ko jaanr*; *vekur pitha* of Assam is used to prepare fermented beverage *Ahom*.[2, 3] Starter culture *Keem* is used for making *Soor*, an alcoholic beverage prepared by the Himalayan traditional people.[4] These starter mixtures add as the inoculums for various microorganisms to bring about fermentation of the beverage.

In Jharkhand, the well known rice-beer is called Handia in the local language meaning "handi" or earthen pot in which it is prepared. The various tribes of this state prepare the drink in their own ways. Handia is made from fermented rice and has an important place in the indigenous communities. The starter mixture used to prepare handia is called ranu meaning "medicine" in Mundari language. It is a mixture of many herbs and various plant parts. In Surguja district of Central India ranu has been documented to be a mixture of roots, barks, rhizomes and leaves of about 20-25 plant species.[5] The ingredients and the method of preparing starter mixture ranu and the fermentation of boiled rice for preparation of rice beer (jhara or harhia) have been recorded as it is practiced by the Oraon and Santhal workers in Terai Tea Gardens.[6] Ethnobotanical studies were conducted among various tribes in different tribal districts of Orissa. It has been found that six plant species are used by the tribal people for preparation of "Bakhar" which is generally used for the fermentation of rice. They were further used to prepare the drink handia.[7] "Sujen" a popular rice beer, has a very important role in the socio-cultural life of Deori tribe of Assam. Sujen is

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drunk in all their festive occasions and celebrations. The starter for this drink is called mod-pitha.[8] The present study pertains to the preparation of ranu as done by the members of Oraon tribe of Khunti area of Jharkhand.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

The study was done in Khunti district of Jharkhand. The people of this village are engaged in cultivation of cereals and vegetables. Some of the families are involved exclusively in the preparation of ranu and selling it in the daily market. The making of handia is restricted and it is prepared only during festivals and private ceremonies. Prior Informed Consent was taken from the knowledgeable persons and a questionnaire was prepared for gathering information.

Ranu is prepared in the months of July- September as the temperature and humidity are ideal for its maturation. The plants or herbs are also readily available during these months. The plants used in the preparation of ranu were photographed and collected. They were dried and preserved using standard herbarium techniques. The medicinal uses of these plants as done by the people were also recorded.

OBSERVATION

The plants used in preparation of ranu are listed in Table 1 along with their Botanical as well as common names. It also shows the parts used and the therapeutic values of them.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Ranu tablets are very important for the fermentation of handia. It is believed that the plants used in ranu provide medicinal properties to the drink and it is used in curing certain diseases or ailments. The Rabha tribe of Goalpara district, Assam, prepares rice beer cake called bakhor consisting of 10 medicinal plants for making the rice beer chako or jongamod. This drink is used by them for treating ailments such as jaundice and diarrhea.[9]

TABLE 1: Plants and their parts used in the preparation of ranu

S.No.	NAME OF THE PLANT	LOCAL NAME	FAMILY	PARTS USED	MEDICINAL USES
1.	*Elephantopus scaber* L.	Jurbi	Asteraceae	Roots	Roots used in dysentery and for stopping vomiting
2.	*Ruellia tuberosa* L.	Chaulia	Acanthaceae	Roots	Roots used in kidney diseases, whooping cough, urinary diseases and stomach problems
3.	*Asparagus racemosus* Willd.	Siyar Poonch	Liliaceae	Roots	Roots used as tonic, diuretic and reduces inflammation
4.	*Coccinia grandis* L. voigt	Jangli kundari	Cucurbitaceae	Roots	Juice of roots is used to treat diabetes, used in joint pain



Asparagus racemosus



Elephantopus scaber



Coccinia grandis



Ruellia tuberosa

After collecting the plants their roots are cut, washed and dried. Then these are powdered and mixed with ground unboiled rice and kneaded into dough. The rice used is of a coarse variety and reddish in colour. Small balls or tablets are made from the dough and placed in a "daliya" or wooden basket layered with dried hay. Several layers of ranu tablets are laid till the basket is fully covered. Then the basket is sealed with hay and kept in a room. This process helps to bring out the moisture from these balls. After two days they are transferred into a room lined with hay a thin muslin cloth. This helps to further the process of precipitation. The balls are turned over several times to ensure proper drying. After week or so the balls are sun dried and then stored.

The making of ranu is done exclusively by the female members and the male members are not allowed to be involved as per their tradition. It is their belief that if ranu is not prepared in the proper manner the taste of handia will not be as good and it may be destroyed. This drink is considered sacred by these people and offered to their deities. It has a cooling effect in summer and keeps stomach cool. It is also given to children as medicine during jaundice and high fever.

CONCLUSION

Handia is an important beverage of the tribal community of Jharkhand. The various tribes almost employ the same method for preparation of handia. But, starter cultures differ for each tribe. Their names are different and the plants used in them also vary according to the region and tradition. The medicinal plants used in ranu are very important for them and by using them in their beverage; these indigenous people make use of the bounties of nature for their purpose. But, sometimes intoxication becomes a problem and improper preparation methods lead to the destruction of age old traditions and practices.

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